protect the property since it has "lost all faith in the state government and its instrumentalities". Reason: frequent non-compliance by Hydraa and Ranganath, who was reportedly even described by the court as "a habitual offender".

While allowing the appeals filed by Ranganath against this order, the division bench said it would remain suspended till November 3 when the matter would come up for hearing again. The bench also directed all parties to maintain status quo over the "subject property".

INSTANT FAME

Hydraa had been set up by way of executive orders on July 19, 2024—intended as a galvanic reform measure that could cut through red-tape and produce results. It especially pursued encroachments around lakes and ponds, which had drastically shrunk Hyderabad water bodies' expanse over the years. Yet, it also frequently found itself at the centre of public attention and judicial scrutiny.

The agency's heavy bulldozing and long-armed piercing machines—dismantling posh apartments and the like—have riled Opposition politicians, big realtors, businessmen, celebrities and even RWAs in apartments allegedly erected on lake FTLs—or 'Full Tank Levels', the lake's maximum footprint during rains, deemed part of the lake.

Hydraa shot to instant national fame in August 2024, when it demolished Telugu film star Akkineni Nagarjuna's luxury venue N Convention, allegedly built on the Thammidikunta pond's FTL at IT hub Madhapur. By the time Nagarjuna managed a stay order from the high court, within hours on a Saturday, most of the demolition was done.

In no time, the BRS was accusing the new CM of rolling in Yogi Adityanath-style "bulldozer raj" to Telangana. Former BRS minister Harish Rao said Hydraa was weaponised to carry out political vendetta. Over the months, as the demolitions continued unabated through 2024-25, Hydraa was even called the bogey that was scaring off

RECLAIMING WATER BODIES Bumruknuddin Dowla Lake post restoration; inset, Commissioner A.V. Ranganath





property buyers and causing a real estate freeze in Hyderabad.

Ranganath, however, tells INDIA TODAY that his approach has always been thoroughly professional, transparent and, above all, in accordance with the Constitution's principles. Hydraa's sole aim, he says, was to protect public wealth as well as water commons, mitigating urban flooding during rains and water scarcity in summers. This monsoon, Hydraa personnel and machinery were seen extracting tonnes of plastic and other waste that choked the city's drainage and stormwater drains for years. Hyderabad was blessed with 1,250 lakes, he says. But their footprint shrunk to half with the real estate frenzy that accompanied the IT boom. The culprit, he says, is a neta-bureaucrat-builder nexus.

Hydraa is the first state agency to mitigate Hyderabad's flooding since the Nizam-era initiatives a century ago, when Sir Mokshagundam Visveswaraya built the Osman and Himayath Sagar reservoirs. Six lakes have been restored, redeveloped and beautified, says Ranganath; another 14 are en route to a rebirth as public recreation spots, with landscaping, open gyms and walking tracks. He calls the contempt cases "the generosity of some powerful encroachers, who excel in court craft"—with individuals bestowing upon him the gift of multiple cases. But he stays undeterred, and says the Revanth regime is "allowing us to carry out our mandate unflinchingly". No instance of singular targeting or motivated cherry-picking can be found in Hydraa's actions, he adds.

The CM defends Hydraa and its chief unequivocally, alleging that encroachers were misleading courts with fake documents, and stressed that postings were the government's prerogative. "Thieves, encroachers and BRS leaders want Hydraa abolished, but we have faith in the judiciary," he says, calling this his "greatest reform". ■